

Nutrition interventions for enhanced child health outcomes in Hanoi, Vietnam

HA L. T. NGUYEN¹, LISA BIBER-FREUDENBERGER², SIMONE KATHRIN KRIESEMER²,
EIKE LUEDELING³, SWE ZIN MOE⁴, HOA BUI THI KHANH⁵, THI SAU NGUYEN⁶,
THI THU GIANG LUU³, CORY WHITNEY³

¹*InnoGenEx Int'l, LTD, R&D, Vietnam*

²*University of Bonn, Center for Development Research (ZEF), Germany*

³*University of Bonn, Inst. Crop Sci. and Res. Conserv. (INRES) - Horticultural Sci., Germany*

⁴*Spectrum-SDKN, Nutrition, Myanmar*

⁵*Vietnam National University of Agriculture, Dept. of Economics, Vietnam*

⁶*Fruit and Vegetable Research Institute, Economics and Marketing Dept., Vietnam*

Food environments are the underlying physical, economic, political and sociocultural conditions that determine the availability, affordability, quality and safety of food as well as the information, advertising and promotion around food.

The regular consumption of processed food and fast food is causing the rate of overweight and obese children in Hanoi to increase rapidly. We identified interventions that could improve children's diets. We applied participatory mapping and focus group discussions to co-develop a comprehensive understanding of families' interactions with urban food environments in Hanoi, Vietnam. Based on participatory maps, we generated spatial information about food access and locations for potential interventions. We included 73 food environment stakeholders in our analysis, including mothers, fathers, grandmothers, grandfathers, children, child-care specialists, "maids" and food vendors. Our research aims to identify possible interventions, for which we aim to project impacts using Decision Analysis methods. Decision Analysis is a methodology that can help decision-makers navigate complex decisions with limited information.

Potential beneficiaries of interventions were identified in small children, primary school students, and young teens, who constitute the major risk groups for poor eating habits that can lead to chronic diseases. Stakeholders noted childhood obesity, likely due to exposure and access to abundant and unhealthy, cheap and convenient food options, parents overfeeding small children and sudden social pressure to lose weight for young teens. Participants expressed concerns regarding food safety, hygiene, and chronic diseases linked to poor eating habits and proposed two concrete interventions to promote healthy habits and nutritional knowledge among children and their families:

Contact Address: Simone Kathrin Kriesemer, University of Bonn, Center for Development Research (ZEF), Genscherallee 3, 53113 Bonn, Germany, e-mail: simonekriesemer@gmx.de